

Letter case

Purpose: To create a visual hierarchy that allows for greater readability and navigation.

Letter case is the difference between uppercase and lowercase letters in the written representation of the English language.

Thus, capitalizing the first letter of the first word of a sentence and proper nouns or capitalizing the first letter of every word in a title or news headline is a function of letter case.

There are two letter case styles that are adopted for writing microcopies for our product. 1. Title case: Capitalize the first letter of every word

For example, "Campaigns - Engage Your Audiences"

2. Sentence case: Capitalize the first letter of the first word and the first letter of a proper noun.

For example, "Campaigns - engage your audiences"

Guidelines:

Rule 1: Use title case for headings, titles and main captions. Use sentence case for descriptive texts, subtitles, additional information, options and choices nested under titles, etc.

Rule 2: Sometimes, multiple titles could be nested one under another. They all need to be treated with the title case. To create hierarchy within them, use typographical elements like font size, font graying, etc.

Rule 3: In title case usage, don't capitalize words like

1. Articles (a, an, the)
2. Conjunctions (and, but, because)
3. Short words (fewer than 4 letters)
4. Prepositions (at, by, to)

Exception: If any of these words come at the beginning of a sentence, they need to be capitalized.

Do this:

Journeys - Reach Wider Audiences at Scale

Don't do this:

Journeys - Reach Wider Audiences At Scale

Rule 4: While using title case, capitalize all other words, including nouns, verbs (including is and other forms of be), adverbs (including very and too), adjectives, and pronouns (including this, that, and its).

However, the UX writer must apply discretion and weigh in the visual esthetics of the microcopy and its appearance as a string.

Rule 5: Use title case for proper nouns, product or feature names and button labels. Do not use quotation marks to mark out these words.

Do this:

Click Continue to proceed.

Use Campaigns to engage users.

Okay, Got It

Don't do this:

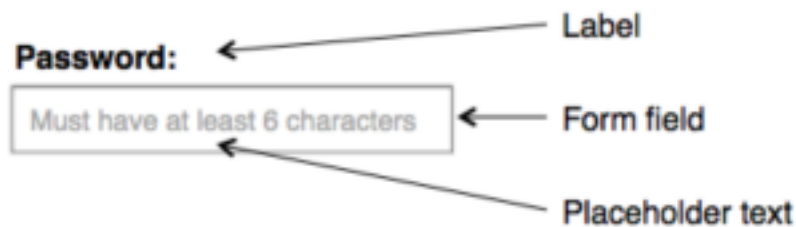
Click "Continue" to proceed.

Use "Campaigns" to engage users.

Okay, Got it

Text input fields and text areas

Purpose: Help people enter accurate information, while reducing cognitive burden and errors.



Text or form fields use UX text as labels, hints, and prefilled text (or placeholder text) for entering text, email addresses, numbers, dates, and plain text searches. Text fields are normally found within a form but can also be part of a modal, search, or card.

The best way to help people enter accurate information and not miss any fields is to avoid overfeeding information and nudges in places that are self-explanatory like message title, description, sender name, etc.

However, if there are qualifications like format, character restrictions, etc. for the text field then they should be included as help text under the field.

Prefilling text fields can be useful if they contain auto-fetchable information like location, time zone, country code, etc. This saves time and gives the person the opportunity to correct it.

Guidelines:

Rule 1: Avoid using placeholder text in text fields where the label completely describes the action or input required. For example, sender name, message description, dropdowns with self explanatory labels, etc.

Rule 1.1: Whenever possible, use action-oriented labels that obviate the need for action oriented placeholder text.

Do this:

Upload Image URL

<No placeholder text>

Don't do this:

Image URL

<Enter image URL>

Rule 2: Qualifying or restrictive information for filling out a text field should be placed under the text field. This could include character limits, time format, date format, etc.

If the qualifying or restrictive information is voluminous as is usually the case with passwords for sensitive web log-ins, it should be displayed in a pop-up box next to the field that stays on while the user is inputting values.

This allows the user to have this vital information right before their eyes as they input values.

Rule 3: Placeholder text is warranted in places where the input value cannot be intuitively understood or the label is missing.

Rule 4: Fields that can be auto-fetched should be pre-filled. These could include country, city, country code, time zone, etc.

What needs to be explored:

1. Use of italics for placeholder text
2. Letter case for placeholder text, especially dropdown list label

Resource:

[https://docs.microsoft.com/en-us/previous-versions/bb158706\(v=msdn.10\)?redirectedfrom=MSDN](https://docs.microsoft.com/en-us/previous-versions/bb158706(v=msdn.10)?redirectedfrom=MSDN)

3. action-oriented labels for text fields that are consistent with the action of inputting value or selecting from drop down.

Numerals vs. words

Rule 1: Spell out zero through nine and use numerals for 10 or greater for days, weeks, and other units of time.

Rule 1.1: Use numerals in snack bars, validation errors, headers, labels, and components with limited space in the UI

Example: You're in the top 5 ✓ Five ❓❓

Rule 2: If one item requires a numeral, use numerals for all the other items of that type.

Example: This folder has 16 images, 7 templates, and 3 videos.

Rule 3: When two numbers that refer to different things must appear together, use a numeral for one and spell out the other.

Example: fifteen 20-page articles

Rule 4: Hyphenate compound numbers when they're spelled out.

Example:

twenty-five fonts

the twenty-first day

Ranges of numbers

Rule 1: In most cases, use *from* and *through* to describe a range of numbers. Example: from 9 through 17

Exceptions:

- Use an en dash in a range of pages or where space is an issue, such as in tables and UI. For example, 2016–2020 and pages 112–120.
- Use *to* in a range of times. For example, 10:00 AM to 2:00 PM. • Don't use *from* before a range indicated by an en dash, such as 10–15.

Percent and percentage

These two terms are not interchangeable. “Percent” means “per hundred” and can either be written out or expressed by the symbol %. Ideally, “percent” is always associated with a specific number:

1. “Percentage” is used to refer to a general relationship rather than a specific measure.
2. A large percentage of the people voted, but only 20 percent of the votes counted.

Rule: Use the percent sign (“%”) with numerals, rather than spelling out “percent.” You don’t need a space between the percent sign and the numeral.

Exceptions:

- Don't use "%" to refer to the symbol itself—refer to the “percent sign.”
- Don't use the percent sign at the beginning of a sentence.
- Don't use the percent sign to mean "percentage."

Ref:

<https://guides.18f.gov/content-guide/our-style/numbers-and-percentages/numbers>

<https://guides.18f.gov/content-guide/our-style/numbers-and-percentages/#percentages>[https://](https://lear)

learn.microsoft.com/en-us/style-guide/numbers#numerals-vs-words

<https://writingexplained.org/ap-style/ap-style-numbers>

<https://www.apstylebook.com/>

Content Type Guidelines/ UI content (other than components)

- Titles
- Descriptions
- Empty states
- Labels
- Transitional text
- Confirmation messages
- Errors

Titles

Purpose: Provide immediate clarity of context and action to be taken.

Titles are labels that indicate top-level hierarchy in the information architecture. Most times, it's the only piece of text your user may read. That means you need to provide context.

Descriptions

Purpose: Help people move forward in the experience knowing what to expect, establish the brand, and reduce liability.

A description is an informational chunk of text, sometimes called body text. They can appear as phrases, sentences, or paragraphs. Most descriptive text can meet its purpose only if people read it. Descriptions are frequently ignored as they're regarded as a "wall of text". If description text is necessary make it as easy to use as possible.

To write clear and concise descriptions, follow the writing goals and principles.

Empty states

Purpose: To set expectation and build excitement while indicating that the space is intentional.

Empty state text can be as simple as a single line of text, or as complex as a title, description, and button. In the simplest case, using the format “To do X, do Y” will help people efficiently move forward while emphasizing the function available (X) and the action to take (Y).

Here are four types of frequently encountered empty states:

- **First use** – Occurs with a new product or service when there is still nothing to show, such as a new account.
- **User cleared** – Occurs when users complete actions such as clearing their inbox or task list, and the result is an empty screen.
- **No results/No data** – Occurs when there is nothing to show. This can happen if someone performs a search and the query is empty or there isn't data available to show (when filtering for a date-range that has no data for example).

Labels

Purpose: Minimize the effort required to understand the experience.

Labels are noun phrases and adjectives that name or describe things. They are used to indicate sections, categories, status, quantity, progress, or unit. The difference between a label and a description is the matter of length and purpose.

To meet their purpose, labels must use specific terms and avoid unfamiliar jargon.

- For the **Stats** section of any feature such as Campaigns or Lifecycle Optimizer, the labels are in title case.

Transitional text

Purpose: Minimize the effort required to understand the experience.

When an experience “hangs”, or is delayed while an action is processed, it’s courteous to inform the person that their waiting is not in vain. Just as a person at the help counter will say, “just a moment while I get that for you”, a digital experience can use transitional text to indicate that a request has been received, and that the person will need to wait for a moment.

In general, transitional text shouldn’t need any additional action or taps. If an action is in progress, use a present continuous tense of the verb like “is uploading” or “are sending”. Use an ellipsis to indicate the delay will be brief. You can also use this to introduce **micro-moments** of delight.

Confirmation messages

Purpose: Reassure the person that the progress or results they expect are complete.

Confirmation messages reassure the person that otherwise invisible processes are complete. They can appear passively in the experience or in sequence in the experience as a momentary pause or step.

They are especially useful when an action is delayed. Set an expectation using the description in such cases.

Errors

Purpose: Help people where they want to go and, if necessary, indicate that there's a problem getting there the way they intended.

Error conditions are what happens when the person can't get where they're going in the experience. Our purpose is to help people move forward, and error conditions are no exception to the rule.

Error messages are easily the most important place in an experience to empathize with the person using the experience, and to maintain our voice.

To do this, stay focused on helping the person do what they were trying to do.

Grammatically, this means using verb-first, brief instruction the same way titles and descriptions do.

To maintain trust, never assign blame to the person, even if the error is their fault. When moving forward isn't an option, make that clear. If you need to, apologize.

There are three main categories of errors in software experiences, organized by how much they interrupt a person:

- Inline errors
- Detour errors
- Blocking errors

When writing an error messages, follow the pattern of telling the person:

- what went wrong
- Why it went wrong and
- How to fix it (if possible and not obvious)

Try to always use a positive tone while informing the user of an error especially in inline errors.

Tell them the action they need to take, instead of telling them what went wrong.

Sentence patterns for inline error messages (Required fields and validation)

{{ Enter a/an (the thing) }}

{{ This {{thing}} is (status). Action to be taken}}

Example:

{{Enter a company name}}

{[Enter a campaign name]}

{[This name is taken. Try another]}